DRUGS IN KERALA

A DANGEROUS HIGH

By Jeemon Jacob

Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra may be creating a *tharangam* (wave) of sorts, as are the raids on Popular Front of India offices, but nothing dominates news in Kerala more than the stray dogs or illicit drugs menace, especially the latter. So drastic is the situation that even the infamous drunken memes are giving way to psychedelic ones. The state is finally waking up to the realisation that matters are getting out of hand.

On August 31, Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan announced in the assembly that his government was clamping down on the menace—with 'vigil committees' to monitor drug users and a data bank of repeat offenders (peddlers) who can now get two years' detention without trial. All state enforcement agencies will be sharing data on drug-related cases too. The opposition Congress has offered unequivocal support, with leader of the opposition V.D. Satheeshan even narrating the harrowing experience of a friend's son who is now admitted at a de-addiction centre.

A special month-long anti-drugs campaign, involving community stakeholders, will begin on October 2. "The campaign involving educational institutions and public places will create better awareness among the youth against drug use," the CM said.

But even as Pinarayi laid out his plans, Kerala saw one of its biggest drug busts on September 21, with Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) officials seizing 22 kg of heroin—a rarely seen drug in the state—from a house in Balaramapuram in the capital. Two people were arrested. DRI sources say the high-quality heroin (apparently worth Rs 150 crore) had come from Mumbai. Other state agencies have now joined the investigation.

Renowned psychiatrist Dr C.J. John, who has studied the impact of drug abuse on Kerala's youth, is not so sure the state's efforts are enough. In the past two years, he has seen a major change in user patterns—his patients now include techies, artists, film celebrities and even housewives. "Many of our brilliant youngsters have fallen into the drug trap. There is a sort of 'cultural pollution' that on the one hand celebrates recreational drug use and on the other considers it a solution to every crisis. We need to look at the issue more realistically...these so-called 'campaigns' aren't helping," says the Kochi-based doctor.

His observations are corroborated by statistics on drug-related crimes, NDPS (Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act) cases, and a February 2021 high court order. The last came after hearing a suo motu case based on a petition by former IPS officer N. Ramachandran, who plotted a detailed map of 'Kerala's migration to deadly drug abuse cases', including violent crimes not notified as drug-related. The division bench directed the state to take proactive steps on March 15, 2021, but critics say the state government and enforcement agencies sat on the order for over a year. Meanwhile, Covid and the restrictions on liquor sales triggered a massive demand for recreational drugs, with cartels spreading their wings in Kerala.

THE INTELLIGENCE DEPT CITES A 2016 SURVEY OF 400 EDUCATIONAL CAMPUSES TO SAY THEY HAD WARNED OF A DRUG ABUSE CRISIS

Ramachandran says it was the bizarre drug-related cases he saw that forced him to approach the court. "I couldn't remain a mute spectator," he says. "As police officers, we see all sorts of crimes every day. But some of the drug-related crimes haunt you, like the teenager who raped his mother under the influence (in Kottayam in 2018), a youth



NARCOTICS NUISANCE

● 2020 ● 2021 ● 2022 (till Sept. 15)

NO. OF RAIDS	NDPS CASES
132,874	4,650
145,624	5,334
97,864	16,986